within administrative structures.

Culturally, a deep river flows between the BJP's hardline bent and cosmopolitan Kolkata. He seeks to lay a bridge over that, expressing a spirit more kindred to Bengal's culture of free thought. His attendance at a theatre production featuring TMC MP Partha Bhowmick was seen as a soft signal on this front, meeting the BJP's greatest weakness in Bengal: the perception that it remains culturally alien.

If the arches and trusses on his bridge seek to be pleasing, its piers are built on ideas of growth. That's meant to persuade those to cross over who are still on the other side, and may be repelled by the language of war: the business class, the urban street, the undecided in the outback. Whether the soft touch filters into the more contentious issues—detention, deportation, demolition—remains to be seen.



**Takeaways**

- **The relatively softer-toned state BJP chief Samik Bhattacharya seeks to emerge as a power centre parallel to CM**
- **It's a division of labour useful to BJP: the urbane Samik is wooing industry, the local business class, and aloof Kolkatans**
- **To investors, he is selling Bengal as a destination that's put Singur behind it. To the *bhadralok*, he speaks like kin**

Can such a division of labour endure? Duality is tricky. Yet, for now, the BJP seems to view the idea as a plus, not a contradiction. Thus, outside Nabanna, Bhattacharya stands as a key counterweight in its Bengal experiment. ■




**A NEW DAY** Surrendered Maoists at a felicitation programme in Ranchi

PTI

▶ JHARKHAND

# The Jharkhand Jungles Quieten

## Often put in the shade by news from Chhattisgarh, its sibling state is pacifying Maoism in its own way

*By* **Amitabh Srivastava**

JHARKHAND'S RECENT MASS MAOIST surrender shows how this part of the war against Left-Wing Extremism (LWE) is winding down. Unlike the first chapter in Chhattisgarh, the endgame won't be dramatic. More akin to its latter half, it's enabled by policy deftness. Chief minister Hemant Soren's Nai Disha (New Direction) policy aims to ensure it truly delivers a sense of closure. Not just an abrupt termination—prefixed by an 'ex', if you like—that leaves seeds on the forest floor. Proof of concept came on May 21 when 27 Maoist cadres came in from the bush at Ranchi's police HQ—25 from the CPI (Maoist), two from another faction, six zonal commanders among them, together facing over 400 cases. They qualified for reward money totalling about Rs 33 lakh, plus compensation for surrendered arms.

A young couple, part of the group, showed why that works. Bij Hansda and his wife Vandana arrived with a six-month-old daughter. Cited reasons for surrender: security, stability. Glimpses of that would have come soon, as they were moved to the Hazaribagh open prison. The facility allows family co-residence; offers education, vocational training, aid.

**Takeaways**

- **Mass surrender by 27 Maoists in Ranchi show the success of Hemant Soren's new policy**

That's key to Soren's line that it's a human-led policy that will sap the insurgency's appeal. What the shadows are lengthening on is a landscape of conflict almost as old as Naxalism—dating from the early 1970s, the insurgency here was a key strand that flowed into the consolidated CPI (Maoist) in 2004. Insurgent footprints, once all over, have thinned to the Saranda-Kolhan forests of West Singhbhum.

Jharkhand had presaged the steep decline Maoist incidents saw nationally. In 2009, it even got its first ex-Maoist zonal commander to enter the Lok Sabha: in Kameshwar Baitha.

Yet its fragmented theatres remain violent. January saw nearly 300 anti-LWE operations in Saranda; one left 16 dead Maoists. The surrenders are from squads linked to top guerrillas Misir Besra and Asim Mandal, who are still at large. Will they follow? ■